

Primary Source Reading 1: The Function Argument

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book I, translated by W. D. Ross (1908) Read before Lesson 15a: What Is the Good Life?

Before you read: Aristotle opens by noting that everyone seems to agree the highest good is “happiness” — and then immediately shows that this agreement is empty, because no one agrees on what happiness actually is. His solution is to ask a strange question: what is a human being’s *function*? As you read, follow the argument by analogy — from craftsmen, to bodily parts, to the human being as a whole.

Everything Aims at Some Good

Every art and every inquiry, and similarly every action and pursuit, is thought to aim at some good; and for this reason the good has rightly been declared to be that at which all things aim.

Verbal Agreement, Real Disagreement

Let us resume our inquiry and state... what is the highest of all goods achievable by action. Verbally there is very general agreement; for both the general run of men and people of superior refinement say that it is happiness, and identify living well and doing well with being happy; but with regard to what happiness is they differ, and the many do not give the same account as the wise. For the former think it is some plain and obvious thing, like pleasure, wealth, or honour; they differ, however, from one another — and often even the same man identifies it with different things, with health when he is ill, with wealth when he is poor.

The Function of Man

Presumably, however, to say that happiness is the chief good seems a platitude, and a clearer account of what it is still desired. This might perhaps be given, if we could first ascertain the function of man. For just as for a flute-player, a sculptor, or an artist, and, in general, for all things that have a function or activity, the good and the ‘well’ is thought to reside in the function, so would it seem to be for man, if he has a function. Have the carpenter, then, and the tanner certain functions or activities, and has man none? Is he born without a function?

Life seems to be common even to plants, but we are seeking what is peculiar to man. Let us exclude, therefore, the life of nutrition and growth. Next there would be a life of perception, but it also seems to be common even to the horse, the ox, and every animal. There remains, then, an active life of the element that has a rational principle.

The Conclusion

Now if the function of man is an activity of soul which follows or implies a rational principle... if this is the case, and we state the function of man to be a certain kind of life, and this to be an activity or actions of the soul implying a rational principle, and the function of a good man to be the good and noble performance of these, and if any action is well performed when it is performed in accordance with the appropriate excellence: if this is the case, human good turns out to be activity of soul in accordance with virtue, and if there are more than one virtue, in accordance with the best and most complete.

But we must add 'in a complete life.' For one swallow does not make a summer, nor does one day; and so too one day, or a short time, does not make a man blessed and happy.

After you read: Notice the shape of the whole argument: Aristotle does not ask “what feels good?” He asks what a human being is distinctively *for* — and answers by process of elimination, stripping away what we share with plants and animals until only rational activity remains. As you move into the lesson, hold onto that last line about the complete life. It is doing more work than it first appears.